Recentering Autonomy and Human Connection: Social Media Platform Alternatives and Their Value for Communities, Developers, and Local Businesses

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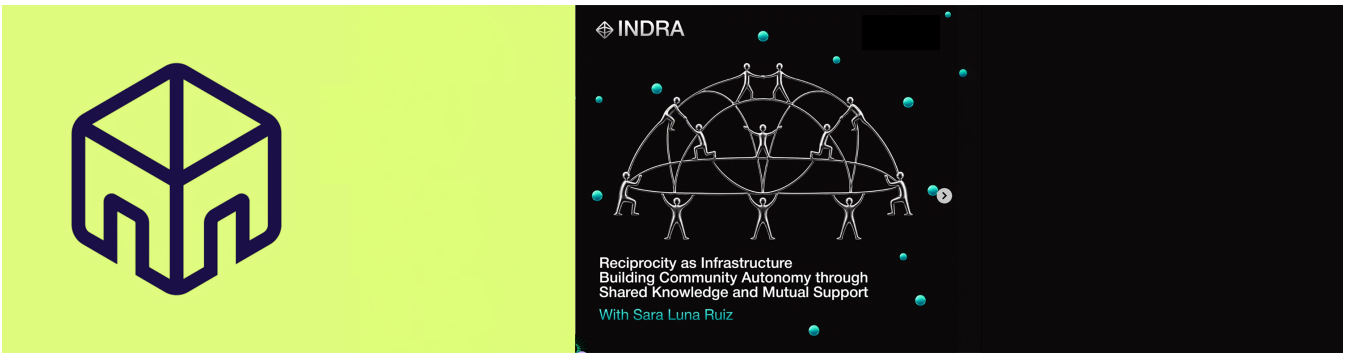


Figure 1: *Left: nebenan.de, Right: INDRA*

Abstract

This study analyzes digital alternatives to commercial platforms such as Facebook and Instagram that use deliberate design decisions to promote local cooperation and real-world interaction. Drawing on two expert interviews, one with Philipp Witzmann, CEO of the neighborhood platform nebenan.de, and one with Sara Luna Ruiz Montoya, developer of the concept-stage reciprocity app INDRA, the paper compares two approaches to designing digital neighborhood infrastructures. The analysis moves from each platform's origins through its development stages and concept to scaling challenges, the tension between ethics and monetization, ethical interface design, verified safety mechanisms, and the integration of local actors. The platform nebenan.de relies on address-verified security, purpose-driven exchange, and relevant local information. INDRA builds a decentralized, token-based reciprocity model. Based on interviews and first-hand insights from the developers, thepaper explores how social networks can grow from micro-applications into larger digital infrastructures and what obstacles they face along the way.

1. Introduction

As we go about our day, living in urban spaces within households that could not be more multifaceted, there are some things most of us do: check our phones and our social networks. Many urban residents probably interact with their physical neighbors less often than they scroll past content from distant strangers on commercial feeds. Mainstream networks such as Facebook and Instagram connect billions of users globally, yet their business models depend on capturing user attention and selling it to advertisers [Zub19,Lan18]. So the question that remains is who actually benefits economically from the free labor of social media users [Geh18].

Many authors discuss how to get out of engagement loops that cause user exhaustion, passive use, and sometimes disconnection from actual neighborhood life [Lan18]. To improve how alternative digital infrastructures develop in the future, it is important to look at the ones that already exist. This paper therefore focuses on two apps: nebenan.de, led by CEO Philipp Witzmann, and INDRA by Sara Luna Ruiz Montoya. Both developers prioritize a task-oriented choice architecture. Their apps originally set out to offer trustworthy, minimalistic social feeds that guide users back into real-world cooperation [Wit26, RM26].

The two interviews represent opposite ends of the developer

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spectrum. On one side is the CEO of nebenan.de, who runs a company with 5 million users across Germany and 120 employees [Wit26]. On the other side is Sara Luna Ruiz Montoya, who created INDRA out of her human rights work to challenge economic structures that reduce human beings to small parts in extractive digital attention machines [RM26].

This paper asks: *What obstacles do alternative platforms face as they grow from micro-applications into larger digital infrastructures, and what would need to change in platform design to support more conscious use?* To answer this, it contributes a comparison of a scaled and a concept-stage neighborhood platform based on first-hand interviews with their developers (Section 4), an analysis of the tensions between ethical goals and economic pressure (Section 5), and design changes for more mindful platform use (Section 5.5).

2. Related Work

Surveillance capitalism and attention. In her theory of surveillance capitalism, Zuboff [Zub19] describes how human experience and behavioral patterns are rendered as raw data, transformed into predictive products, and sold to advertisers. Within this framework, interface design serves the financial interests of advertisers rather than the autonomy or well-being of the user, and screen time itself becomes the primary commodity. Lanier [Lan18] adds that commercial social networks work as "behavior modification" empires: unpredictable rewards such as likes, comments, and notifications condition users to compulsively check their screens. Di Geronimo et al. [DGBF*20] show that such manipulative interface patterns, so-called dark patterns, are common in popular mobile apps.

Alternative social media and platform cooperativism. Gehl [Geh18] describes alternative social media as platforms built as a critical response to corporate social media, which let users share and connect without commercializing their communication. Scholz [Sch16] proposes platform cooperativism, in which platforms are owned and democratically governed by their users and workers instead of investors. Both perspectives ask not only how a platform is designed, but who owns it and how it is financed.

Reciprocity and coordination. Time banks, in which members earn credits for each hour of help and spend them on help from others, are a pre-digital form of reciprocity; Seyfang [Sey04] finds that they can strengthen community self-help, but depend on local organizers. Stafford Beer's Project Cybersyn in Chile (1971–1973) used a network of telex machines and computers to coordinate the country's nationalized industries in near real time [Med11], an early attempt to coordinate complex social systems through networks rather than market mechanisms.

Creative work and participation. Bishop [Bis23] describes "influencer creep", in which artists are pushed into constant self-branding, algorithmic optimization, and performed authenticity to stay visible on platforms like Instagram. Research on participation shows that most users of online communities only read and never post [Nie06], and that passive use tends to be linked with worse emotional outcomes in general feeds, but not in group contexts [GH24].

This paper adds the perspective of the people who build alternative platforms and examines how their ethical goals hold up against the economic pressures of growth.

3. Methodology

This paper uses expert interviews to gain fresh perspectives on app structures that support more conscious and mindful use. They give first-hand insight into the intentions and decisions behind a platform, which are rarely documented publicly.

Cases. We chose nebenan.de and INDRA because they represent two different stages of development: an established product on the market and a concept that is still being designed. Users on nebenan.de sign up with their real names and connect in a trusted space. The platform offers neighborly help, a local marketplace, groups, events, local information, and services, both in the browser and via the app. It is Germany's largest neighborhood platform, with over 5 million users in more than 15,000 neighborhoods, 120 employees, and total costs of about €11 million [Wit26]. INDRA is a digital reciprocity platform that helps people with limited local networks, such as migrants, creatives, freelancers, and students, exchange skills, knowledge, and support within trusted communities. Participation is planned to be free and structured through a credit system that rewards contribution, and the platform is to be sustained by institutions that receive aggregated, non-personal insights in return. INDRA "has been developed over several years through research, design, prototyping, community conversations, and strategic work", but it is not yet in operation [RM26].

Participants. Philipp Witzmann is the CEO of nebenan.de. Sara Luna Ruiz Montoya is the founder and developer of INDRA. Her motivation is rooted in social activism and human rights work in her native Colombia, where she worked alongside marginalized communities and saw how extractive structures appropriate the labor of hard-working individuals. She conceptualizes INDRA as an intervention against architectures that reduce human beings to "individuals in a machine that just keeps running", centered on the rhythm of giving and receiving and measuring success by the simple act of helping one person and changing their day [RM26]. She names Project Cybersyn [Med11] as a precedent for task-oriented micro-infrastructures that redirect digital coordination back into local community resilience.

Interviews. Two interviews took place in September 2026. The author interviewed Witzmann via video call; Ruiz Montoya joined this interview and asked questions from her perspective as a developer. The author then interviewed Ruiz Montoya in person about INDRA, its concept (the INDRA method), and her view on the conversation with Witzmann. We chose open questions over narrow ones. This allowed the conversations to develop naturally and gave the interviewees room to expand on the topics they considered most important. The questions covered the same themes for both platforms: origins and concept, the tension between ethics and monetization, community value, interface design, safety, the integration of local actors, and scaling. Both interviews were recorded. Timestamps in square brackets, e.g. [03:20], refer to the recording of the Witzmann interview [Wit26]. Quotes were translated into English where necessary and lightly edited for readability without changing their meaning.

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Analysis. We sorted the statements from both interviews by these themes and compared the two platforms theme by theme. Notes from a debrief between the author and Ruiz Montoya after the Witzmann interview were also included. For nebenan.de, we describe practices that are in operation; for INDRA, we describe what is planned.

4. Findings

4.1. The Tension Between Ethics and Monetization

nebenan.de is not yet fully profitable [03:20]. It has three revenue streams [Wit26]: voluntary donations from community members who choose to support the platform; monthly subscriptions from local businesses (out of approximately 130,000 registered business profiles, around 6,000 pay for premium visibility); and programmatic display advertising sold to regional and national brands based on impression volume (CPM/TKP).

According to Witzmann, the order in which a platform grows and earns money matters. Commercial social media usually grows past one million users before it starts to monetize. nebenan.de tried to secure revenue early, and this created lasting friction: "Because we had to monetize quite early, we never spent enough time building a kick-ass product for our users" [06:15]. His advice to founders is therefore: "Try not to sell revenue too early" [07:18].

Advertising is the most demanding of the three streams, because ad-funded models need very large numbers of impressions. Low screen time, which fits the platform's values, becomes a financial problem:

> "Meta has 3 hours a day; nebenan.de has seven minutes per week on average. Monetizing through advertising is really hard if you don't have enough impressions." [11:04]

In his words, "an app like nebenan.de needs billions of impressions a day to be interesting for advertisers" [07:18]. The pressure also changed which advertisers it was willing to accept:

> "In the beginning we also had a list of companies we didn't want to work with. I secured a €500,000 deal with Deutsche Bank, and that's when the whole company went nuts! [...] Over time we threw all of this overboard. We said: if we want to monetize, we need to monetize properly." [05:21]

At first, the team rejected Deutsche Bank because the bank finances wars. Today they would accept the deal. Witzmann justifies this with statistics rather than values: the share of nebenan.de users who bank with Deutsche Bank is the same as the share across Germany.

To grow its advertising income without using addictive engagement traps, nebenan.de introduced new key performance indicators (KPIs) such as session depth and length, participation rate, and DAU over MAU, i.e. how many people come more than once on a daily basis [11:28]. The goal behind these KPIs is to make the platform a daily habit:

> "I want nebenan to be the first source of truth. Real information from real people about real places in the neighborhood they live in. To become that, you need to become a habit at some point. I don't mean people spending three hours on their phone." [15:34]

This shift caused disagreement inside the company:

> "Our team especially said: 'No, we really don't want that! We're really happy if they come once a week.' And then I can tell them: 'Yeah, that's great, but then I can't pay you.' We need to find a middle ground. It's not romantic, but it's the truth if you want to build a company." [16:07]

INDRA takes the opposite approach. It is designed to reject advertising, data harvesting, and market speculation entirely. Instead of financial capital, it plans a non-speculative merit ledger (INDRA Coins) based on an "Earn-to-Ask" model: users must contribute to the community before they can make new requests. Instead of ad revenue, INDRA plans to fund its technical operations through institutional partnerships and municipal sponsors, while the INDRA method itself names long-term financial viability as an open question [RM26]. This model would protect users from ad-driven engagement loops, but it shifts the platform's dependence onto institutions, whose priorities may one day conflict with community autonomy.

4.2. Community Value and Reciprocity

How community value is created, and who profits from it, is the central difference between the two platforms. On nebenan.de, social value is based on generalized, informal reciprocity: neighbors help each other without expecting anything in return. About 30% of all items on the platform are free giveaways, services, and objects [08:32]. Witzmann sees the quality of this content as the reason people even donate money:

> "It's not betting content, it's not political, it's not fake or false news, and it's not AI. So it's good content, and it gives value to the people who see it. That's why many people donate money to a company, which is pretty rare." [16:47]

To recognize active participation, nebenan.de uses light gamification: badges for especially engaged neighbors and for voluntary supporters. However, as the platform grew, the way people use it changed: "In the beginning, it was about connecting people offline. Now, many people are information takers or gatherers" [12:54]. This creates a tension. Active neighbors create the social cohesion and mutual aid that attract users to the app, but the platform earns money from the resulting passive attention, by selling it as ad impressions.

INDRA plans to address this imbalance by building reciprocity directly into its infrastructure, instead of treating neighborly help as free content for advertising. It sorts community value into three areas: knowledge and guidance, hands-on physical support, and material resources. The Earn-to-Ask rule is meant to prevent a growing group of passive takers, because every participant must keep a balanced contribution record. Contribution radars and network maps are planned to show collective impact in real time and make social capital visible [RM26].

The INDRA method also raises open questions about the effects

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of measuring mutual aid. Recording favors on a digital ledger risks turning spontaneous kindness into a transaction, bringing back the kind of quantification that alternative platforms want to leave behind. Drawing on experiences with time banks [Sey04], it notes that such systems often suffer from uneven participation across social groups and depend on dedicated local organizers. Ruiz Montoya's approach is to involve many small businesses that also offer goods for free and act as messengers between local actors [RM26].

4.3. Ethical Interface Design

Witzmann describes the platform's values mainly through what it does not do: "We don't build filter bubbles or use algorithms to basically glue you to the screen and keep your attention on our product for ages" [10:04]. Instead, users are given more control over what they see. One example is the so-called cat content problem: after many complaints about too much cat content, users can now hide a specific kind of post just for themselves, and the team is thinking about going further [12:54].

At the same time, nebenan.de uses features that increase engagement: "We send personalized notifications, which helps with engagement. We're now adding local news, which drives engagement like crazy, because it's relevant for neighborhoods" [11:58]. The largest of these projects is an AI-supported local news service. Witzmann built eight AI agents that find sources for eight local news categories per neighborhood, and a crawler that gathers the information and builds a newsletter from it. According to him, almost 35% of users engaged with these posts, and the service is now tested live in about 50 mid-sized German cities, "because most of them don't have a local section in the newspaper anymore" [22:26].

4.4. Verified Safety Mechanisms

To protect its local communities from bots, trolls, and hate speech, nebenan.de requires users to verify their home address, for example with a code sent by post, an ID check, or a video call. This high barrier ties each digital identity to a real place. We experienced this ourselves when signing up: users cannot simply move between neighborhoods. According to Witzmann, this strengthens trust within each neighborhood. To safeguard this ecosystem, nebenan.de also has a relatively large team for data safety and enforces a strict trust and safety protocol. As the platform grows, so do the attacks against it:

> "Sometimes about 10 million email-and-password combinations are thrown against our system per minute. [. . .] [. . .] The more relevant we become, the more attacks we receive." [28:18]

While nebenan.de builds trust through central address verification and its own trust and safety team, INDRA plans to rely on a decentralized blockchain and self-executing smart contracts to enforce agreements transparently, without a central intermediary [RM26]. However, how INDRA will handle trust, disputes, and safety for diverse and vulnerable groups at scale is still unproven.

4.5. Integration of Local Actors

On nebenan.de, local businesses are integrated through business profiles. When asked whether the platform might also support freelance content creators who build a business as a single person, as many do on Instagram, Witzmann made a clear distinction:

> "If they're local, yes. But for content creators, for example, I'd say no, because they need a beyond-local, viral reach that you can't get with us. But if you have a store, or you're a mobile massage therapist or a yoga teacher, then you sign up with us, and we're a good product for you, because you need local residents as clients." [26:25]

Accordingly, Witzmann sees WhatsApp and Facebook groups in rural areas and classifieds sites such as Kleinanzeigen as competitors [08:32], while Instagram and TikTok compete only for attention, "not as a whole product" [09:03].

The platform also analyzes what its users post in order to find new partners. For example, 8,000 offers for flats led to work on a deal with ImmoScout [19:34]. Some of this data is shared publicly, such as a graph showing that Dresden is the most helpful city [19:50].

Witzmann also positions nebenan.de as a partner for public institutions. For local news, he wants regional newspapers to join and draws on sources such as city administrations, local clubs, and the police [21:31]. He sees this as a democratic task, because without local newspapers only "a very generic thing" is left, "which is also heavily driving de-democratization in rural areas, because many people there only get their information through a heavy filter bubble" [23:13]. A second example is care. Witzmann believes that "the care system in Germany will collapse within the next five years" [23:59]. In a pilot project with the Diakonie in eight cities, caretakers note down non-medical needs of the people they visit, such as grocery shopping or company, and post them on the platform. On average, it takes seven minutes until a neighbor offers to help. Witzmann is open about the strategic goal behind this:

> "It's a very strategic project. [. . .] It doesn't help us grow, and it doesn't bring us money. It's something that will bring us money, credibility, and demand, including from the state side, in the future." [24:58]

INDRA plans to integrate local actors differently. Municipalities, institutions, and ethical businesses are meant to be not advertisers but sponsors of collective well-being. In return for their support, they would receive aggregated, non-personal data about local supply and demand, resource gaps, and neighborhood needs. The INDRA method itself flags the privacy risks of this model: in small, close-knit communities, even anonymized data can be traced back to vulnerable individuals, such as migrants or low-income students. This requires strict rules for data sharing and algorithmic oversight [RM26].

4.6. Scaling Challenges

nebenan.de shows the costs that come with scale: reaching over five million users required the organization described in Section 3. Compared with Meta or Nextdoor, the company works on a "relatively thin spread". To manage this, it recently reorganized around AI tools:

> "All our engineers work with Claude Code, and everyone

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> at the company works with Cowork. [. . .] Now we have teams, including tech, that focus only on increasing value for our users." [06:34]

Growth also brings the security threats described in Section 4.4, which require enterprise-level infrastructure.

For INDRA, which currently exists as a design concept and prototype, the main scaling challenge is reaching critical mass. A reciprocity network only works if enough people in one area offer and request help. Without this local density, the Earn-to-Ask ledger stalls. INDRA's planned open-source blockchain framework would offer transparency and permanent transaction records, but it must still overcome hurdles in usability, safety, and governance. If it grows beyond close-knit communities, it will need moderation that prevents exploitation, without the administrative costs that pushed nebenan.de toward advertising. The concept also leaves open the option to stay in smaller groups that focus on reciprocity [RM26].

5. Discussion

5.1. Growth or Values: Which Model Can Last?

The two cases show two different answers to the same problem. nebenan.de chose growth and accepted compromises to survive. Witzmann describes the path most platforms follow:

> "We want to build a product that people like, that goes viral, and that people want to use, and if we manage that, monetization will follow. Look at how it worked for TikTok and the others, for example. The other option [. . .] is to offer more products to get high engagement with smaller target groups. Then you have to monetize through a subscription." [07:18]

For Ruiz Montoya, it was somewhat disappointing to see how many of nebenan.de's original concepts had been given up for the sake of growth and monetization, but her belief in her own system remained strong [RM26]. From her perspective as the developer of INDRA, three differences stood out.

First, the two platforms are moving in different directions. In our debrief after the interview, we noted that nebenan.de is moving toward "news and neighbors' posts" rather than "direct favors", which we described as "a completely different model" from INDRA's.

Second, the two platforms relate differently to mainstream social media. Witzmann sees Instagram and TikTok as competitors for attention and impressions, even though nebenan.de rejects their methods. INDRA does not compete for attention at all, since its value lies in completed exchanges, not in time spent in the app.

Third, both platforms turn community data into value for partners, but for different goals. nebenan.de contextualizes its posts to build commercial deals, such as with ImmoScout, while INDRA plans to share aggregated, non-personal data with sponsors to direct institutional support toward neighborhood needs.

For Ruiz Montoya, these differences strengthened her conviction that INDRA can stay true to its values by measuring balanced contributions instead of attention, and by designing reciprocity into the system from the start [RM26].

5.2. Engagement Without Addiction

Not every engagement feature is harmful. nebenan.de's badges for engaged neighbors are a mild form of gamification that rewards helping rather than scrolling. The cat content example shows that user control can reduce unwanted content without an algorithm deciding for the user.

Other features are more ambiguous. Witzmann values that the platform's content is "not AI" [16:47], yet its most successful new feature, local news, is gathered by AI agents and crawlers. This shifts the platform from "real information from real people" toward automated information for passive readers. Since most users of any online community only read and never post [Nie06], and passive use tends to be linked with worse emotional outcomes in general feeds but not in group contexts [GH24], whether nebenan.de remains a neighborhood group or becomes a local news feed may matter for its users' well-being.

This leads to a simple question: what is the point of keeping engagement low? The team's position, that they are "really happy if they come once a week" [16:07], describes a platform that is used when it is needed, and then put away. The ad model does not reward this. Reciprocity-based models like INDRA's might, while nebenan.de tries to solve this by expanding its features and collaborations.

5.3. Verification: Exclusivity or Belonging?

Transparency and verification create trust, but they also draw boundaries. Address verification ties people to one neighborhood and keeps outsiders out. This can create a deeper connection within the group, but it can also create exclusivity, for example for people without a fixed address or without official documents. INDRA's decentralized approach avoids a central gatekeeper but must find other ways to create the same level of trust.

5.4. Niche Platforms and Self-Presentation

One open question is whether moving toward niche platforms would reduce the human drive toward individuality and self-branded artistic personas that Bishop calls influencer creep [Bis23], or do the opposite. Witzmann's answer on content creators (Section 4.5) shows that the design of a niche platform already decides what kind of self-presentation it supports: nebenan.de makes room for people who offer a local service, not for people whose business depends on being seen by as many people as possible. In other words, removing the pressure to perform for a mass algorithm might not remove the urge for self-presentation altogether. Instead, it could separate artists who use these platforms mainly to communicate and connect with others from those who keep producing content without real intention, regardless of the app's design.

5.5. Relevant Changes in Platform Design

Based on both cases, we identify the following design changes that could support more conscious and mindful use:

- **Redefine success metrics:** move away from daily active users, session length, and time in the app, toward task completion and low screen time while still offering valuable engagement.

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- **Replace ad-impression funding:** move away from CPM/TKP models, which force platforms to chase billions of impressions, toward non-speculative token ledgers (as planned in INDRA), municipal sponsorships, or supporter programs.
- **Give users control over their feeds:** replace viral black-box algorithms with geographically bounded feeds and clear user controls, such as hiding specific kinds of posts.
- **Serve passive users fairly:** offer clear, useful civic information, such as local news and municipal updates, to the passive majority without manipulative engagement traps.
- **Verify real-world identity carefully:** tie user profiles to verified addresses to build real-world trust and protect against bot networks and trolling, while making sure that verification does not exclude vulnerable groups and that personal profiles stay minimal.

5.6. Limitations

This study is based on two interviews. The statements of the interviewees are self-reports that could not be checked against independent data, such as usage statistics or the effect of address verification on trust. The comparison is also asymmetric: nebenan.de is an established company, while INDRA's features are still plans. Ruiz Montoya took part in both interviews and is the developer of one of the compared platforms, which may have shaped the questions and their interpretation. Finally, translated quotes may lose nuances of the original conversation.

6. Future Work

For nebenan.de, the next step is a shift from informal favor exchange toward becoming a civic infrastructure for neighborhood life. Witzmann's plans go beyond aggregating news: "We're also thinking about starting some local journalistic content. That's what we're focusing on the most" [23:13]. This is a hopeful development, especially for the many mid-sized towns and rural areas that no longer have a local newspaper. At the same time, a platform that produces its own journalism, partly with AI agents and crawlers, takes on editorial responsibility: who checks the facts, who decides what counts as news, and how independent can local reporting be when it also has to drive engagement? If nebenan.de wants to become a trusted "first source of truth", these questions will matter as much as its reach. Future research could also follow whether the reorganization around AI tools frees teams to focus on users, or only lowers costs while the pressure to grow stays the same.

For INDRA, the most important next step is moving from concept to practice. A pilot in a single neighborhood would show whether the Earn-to-Ask model reaches critical mass, how people feel about having their favors recorded, and whether institutional sponsors can be found without compromising the platform's independence. One of INDRA's planned features shows how playful and physical its approach can be: every new business that joins the network will receive an animated zine that it can print and hand out as a first giveaway to new customers [RM26]. The challenge will be to keep such features as invitations to connect, rather than as marketing tools.

Looking further ahead, the two models may not need to stay separate. Future work could explore whether reciprocity-based tools like INDRA's could complement large platforms like nebenan.de, reaching people that neither platform could reach alone. Further research should also examine who is included and who is left out by each verification model. Finally, interviews with the founders of other alternative platforms, together with the perspectives of users and local businesses themselves, would help show whether the tensions described here are specific to neighborhood platforms or part of a wider pattern.

7. Conclusion

nebenan.de and INDRA approach the problem from very different starting points: a large platform used across generations, focused on safety and on anchoring users in their neighborhoods, and a concept for people with limited local networks. Yet their intended concepts share a lot: both want to strengthen real-world connection, both reject the attention-capturing mechanics of mainstream social media, and both see neighborly help as the core value of a digital community.

Despite the tensions between ethics and monetization, the interview also shows what nebenan.de does well. Instead of manipulative algorithms, it gives users control over the kinds of posts they see. Its local news and notifications offer residents useful information that is hard to find elsewhere, and projects such as the Diakonie care pilot show how the platform's business can connect with real social needs. At the same time, nebenan.de shows how strongly the business model shapes the design. For a platform of its size, advertising and the need for impressions pull the design toward habits, notifications, and more time in the app, even when the team would rather be "happy if they come once a week". INDRA, still at the concept stage, has the chance to choose a different path from the start, but it must still prove that its token-based model and institutional funding can work at scale without creating new dependencies.

Recentering autonomy and human connection, as the title of this paper suggests, therefore depends not only on good intentions and ethical interface design. It depends on building funding models and success metrics that reward platforms for helping people connect, rather than for holding their attention. Alternative platforms do not fail or succeed on their intentions alone, but on the structures that carry those intentions through growth. If those structures can be built differently, then the question is no longer whether social media can bring people closer together, but who is willing to pay for it, and how.

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